Does Representation Geometry Explain Distance-Based OOD Ranking? Scorer Invariance and a Prespecified Intervention Study

Duc-Vinh Tran and Quyet-Thang Huynh

***Abstract*—**

Distance-based estimators are widely used to flag domain-shifted inputs before a clinical model acts on them, and representation geometry has been reported to track how well they perform across frozen foundation-model backbones. Reading that association as an explanation requires a step correlational comparison cannot supply: the geometry a metric measures must be geometry the scorer actually reads. We make that requirement precise and then evaluate it. We show that the spectral-tempering operator used to match geometry sets the condition number in closed form, $\kappa(\Sigma') = \kappa(\Sigma)^{1-\gamma}$, while leaving Mahalanobis scoring exactly invariant once its parameters are refit; for that estimator the geometry-matched comparison therefore has no difference available to detect, and its null is entailed by the algebra rather than measured. Cosine, k-nearest-neighbour, and kernel-density scoring are not invariant and remain admissible. Empirically, we report a prespecified within-backbone intervention study on a frozen dermatology foundation model (PanDerm ViT-L/16), with ISIC 2019 in-distribution and PAD-UFES-20 domain-shifted, neither in the pretraining corpus. Backbone, feature layer, splits, and scorer definitions are held fixed while the representation is reshaped along a dose ladder against a matched-budget control, with implementation-integrity gating, an explicit manipulation check, and multiplicity correction fixed before execution. Domain information and in-distribution task performance persisted after intervention, and the targeted geometry moved measurably, so the absence of a relationship is not an artefact of a destroyed representation. The probe–reliability dissociation reproduced in direction but roughly two orders of magnitude smaller than originally reported (mean AUROC gap 1.6×10^{-3} here against 0.333 there under the directed convention, or 0.137 read orientation-free), with all estimators above 0.99 on the unmodified representation. We therefore do not report a test of the explanatory account. We report the boundary of where it can be tested: a regime in which every estimator already exceeds 0.99 leaves this design little room to observe an account operating, and in which one of the four estimators cannot respond to the manipulation at all. This locates what such an evaluation requires, and it is a claim about what the present study can support, not about what holds in regimes it did not evaluate.

***Index Terms*—Out-of-distribution detection, reliability estimation, representation geometry, foundation models, causal evaluation, prespecification, dermatology.**

I. Introduction

Automated diagnostic systems deployed in dermatology routinely encounter images acquired under conditions their training data does not represent: different capture devices, illumination, populations, and clinical settings. Because a classifier's confidence is unreliable on such inputs, deployed systems commonly pair the classifier with a separate safeguard that estimates whether an input falls outside the training distribution. Distance-based estimators—Mahalanobis distance to class centroids and its relatives—remain the dominant choice for this role, and they rest on a geometric premise: that inputs from an unseen acquisition domain occupy a measurably different region of the representation space than the training population does.

Two lines of evidence complicate that premise, and they have so far remained separate.

The first concerns whether the premise holds at all. On convolutional representations of skin lesions, a linear probe recovered acquisition-domain identity at high accuracy—establishing that the domain signal was present and linearly decodable—while distance-based estimators operating on the same representations performed near chance [1]. The information distinguishing the domains was decodable, but not accessible to the estimator intended to exploit it. This dissociation is clinically relevant because it describes a failure mode in which the safeguard reports normality precisely where a probe could establish that the input is anomalous.

The second concerns what governs estimator performance. Across a range of frozen vision foundation-model backbones, two properties of the in-distribution representation—its local intrinsic dimensionality (LID) and the decay profile of its within-class covariance spectrum—were found to track how well Mahalanobis-style estimators perform [2]. That work reports an association measured across representations produced by different pretraining regimes, and characterizes it as tracking rather than causation.

Whether the second line of evidence explains the first is an open question, and it is the question we take up. An association observed across representations is consistent with several readings: geometry may govern what distance-based estimators can recover; or both geometry and estimator performance may follow jointly from properties of the pretraining regime that distinguish one backbone from another. These readings are not separable by comparing backbones, because backbones differ in many respects at once. Distinguishing them requires holding the representation's provenance fixed and intervening on geometry directly—and if geometry governs accessibility in the sense the dissociation would require, such an intervention should change what distance-based estimators recover from a

D.-V. Tran and Q.-T. Huynh are with the School of Information and Communication Technology, Hanoi University of Science and Technology, Hanoi 100000, Vietnam (e-mail: vinh.td225538@sis.hust.edu.vn; thang.huynhquyet@hust.edu.vn).

Corresponding author: Q.-T. Huynh.

representation whose domain content is otherwise preserved.

We examined where that hypothesis can be evaluated, on a frozen dermatology foundation model, within a single fixed backbone rather than across backbones. Rather than proposing a new out-of-distribution detector, we characterised the conditions an explanatory reading requires, under a prespecified protocol incorporating implementation-integrity verification, manipulation checking, and prespecified statistical analysis with multiplicity correction fixed in advance of execution. Only checkpoints clearing both verification stages enter the causal comparison.

Our findings delimit where such a reading can be evaluated at all, under the evaluated backbone, layer, and task, rather than adjudicating it. The probe–reliability dissociation remained statistically detectable, but at approximately two orders of magnitude smaller a margin than originally reported, with distance-based estimators already operating near ceiling on the unmodified representation. The two prespecified geometry metrics showed no Holm-significant association with estimator performance. These results indicate that associations observed across representations warrant direct intervention-based evaluation before being interpreted as explanatory.

This study is organised around three questions, fixed before execution.

RQ1 Can targeted geometric properties be systematically manipulated while preserving task utility and domain information?

RQ2 Within a fixed frozen backbone, do changes in prespecified geometry metrics predict changes in distance-based OOD ranking?

RQ3 When geometry is matched across nominally different intervention configurations, does OOD performance follow geometry or intervention configuration?

The contributions are three.

- **A scorer-relevant invariance formalization.** We separate raw representation geometry, the geometry a scorer actually reads, score magnitude, cross-domain ranking, and AUROC, which the literature commonly treats as one chain. A geometry metric earns interpretation as a predictor of ranking only after the first two are shown to coincide. We supply that step for the operator used here (Section III-H): it sets the condition number in closed form while leaving Mahalanobis scoring exactly invariant, so one of the four estimators is structurally unable to respond to it, and three are not.
- **A gated within-backbone intervention protocol.** Cross-backbone studies vary architecture, pretraining corpus, objective, dimension, and feature layer together; when geometry and performance move together there, geometry may be an explanation or merely a correlate of backbone provenance. We hold backbone, extraction pipeline, feature layer, splits, evaluation protocol, and scorer definitions fixed, and intervene on the representation output alone, behind an implementation-integrity gate and an explicit manipulation check.
- **Empirical boundary evidence in a near-ceiling regime.** The contribution is not that geometry fails to predict AUROC. It is a characterisation of where the question can be asked: domain information and task utility survive the intervention and the targeted geometry moves, so a trivial explanation is excluded; the prespecified metrics nonetheless do not account for ranking in the evaluated configuration; and baseline performance above 0.99 for every estimator bounds what any such account could have been observed to explain here.

II. Related Work

A. Distance-Based Reliability Estimation

Distance-based out-of-distribution detection scores an input by its position relative to the training distribution in representation space. The Mahalanobis detector fits class-conditional Gaussians to training features and scores an input by its minimum Mahalanobis distance to any class centroid [3]; nearest-neighbour, kernel-density, and cosine-to-centroid variants replace the parametric fit with local or directional statistics but retain the same premise, that distributional novelty manifests as geometric displacement. The family is well suited to clinical deployment because it requires no outlier data at training time and attaches to an existing classifier without retraining [3]. The premise is nonetheless an assumption about representation geometry, and this paper concerns the conditions under which it holds.

B. Decodability Versus Accessibility

Linear probing trains a classifier independently of the model in order to measure what information a representation linearly encodes [4]. The distinction matters here because a probe and a distance-based estimator can disagree: a probe may recover acquisition-domain identity from a representation on which distance-based scores are uninformative. Prior work on convolutional networks reported exactly this dissociation for skin-lesion representations: probes recovered acquisition-domain identity at 0.72–0.81 AUROC while Mahalanobis-family scores sat near 0.40 under the standard higher-distance-is-more-OOD convention [1]. That report is explicit that the scores did not approach chance but were directionally misaligned: their orientation-free separability was 0.58–0.60, so the ordering retained signal while pointing the wrong way. That report motivates the present evaluation; whether it describes the frozen foundation-model regime is the question we examine.

C. Representation Geometry and Estimator Performance

Estimator performance has been linked to two properties of the in-distribution representation: its local intrinsic dimensionality, estimated by the Levina–Bickel maximum-likelihood estimator [5], and the decay profile of its within-class covariance spectrum [2]. That work evaluates a range of frozen vision foundation-model backbones and reports that these two quantities track how Mahalanobis-style detector performance varies across them. The relationship is characterized as tracking rather than causation, and the study does not employ probing classifiers or examine the dissociation

described above. Its interventions target an internal term of its own derivation rather than detector performance itself.

A substantial body of work manipulates related geometric quantities directly, mostly outside out-of-distribution detection. Post-hoc whitening and isotropy-oriented transforms reshape the covariance spectrum of frozen embeddings, either by removing dominant principal directions [6], by full or partial decorrelation [7], [8], or by graded per-dimension spectral reweighting [9]. Evidence on semantic cost is mixed: partial-strength variants report downstream gains, while a systematic evaluation of five full-strength whitening variants reports degradation on classification tasks [10]. A separate line targets geometry during training rather than post hoc, through spectral or intrinsic-dimensionality regularizers [11], [12]. We draw the geometry-manipulation operator used in our causal comparison from the post-hoc, dose-controllable end of this literature, for reasons detailed in Section III.

D. Frozen Foundation Models and Cross-Backbone Comparison

Dermatological image analysis has moved toward large pretrained encoders used as frozen feature extractors, with lightweight task-specific components trained on top [13]. In frozen foundation models, the representation geometry is primarily inherited from large-scale pretraining rather than optimized end-to-end for the downstream clinical task. Comparing geometry and detector performance across such backbones establishes that the two covary, but backbones differ simultaneously in pretraining corpus, objective, architecture, and scale, so an association measured across them cannot separate a geometric explanation from a shared dependence on pretraining. Distinguishing these readings requires holding provenance fixed and intervening on geometry directly. Our contribution is an evaluation of that kind, in the same spirit as validation studies that test whether a reported effect survives a change of setting, applied here to the explanatory status of a reported association rather than to its reproducibility.

III. Methods

A. Backbone and Populations

All experiments use a single frozen pretrained dermatology foundation model, PanDerm ViT-L/16 [13], as a feature extractor. The backbone is never updated: every intervention described below operates on its output embeddings, which are 1024-dimensional. Embeddings were extracted once under a fixed preprocessing pipeline and stored as an immutable artifact with checksum verification, so that all downstream analyses share bit-identical inputs.

The in-distribution population is ISIC 2019 [14], [15], [16], comprising 25,331 dermoscopic images across eight diagnostic classes. We partition it with a fixed seed into a held-out evaluation set (20%, $n = 5{,}067$), a validation set (20% of the remainder, $n = 4{,}053$), and a training population ($n = 16{,}211$) used to fit all distribution-dependent quantities. The validation split is not used in the analyses reported here. This partition is specific to the present study and does not correspond to the challenge's own splits.

The domain-shifted population is PAD-UFES-20 [17], contributing 2,298 close-up clinical images collected in Brazil; the modality difference from ISIC's dermoscopic images accompanies differences in device, population, and clinical setting. PAD-UFES-20 is mapped into the same eight-class label space and populates six of the eight classes. The evaluation population combines held-out ISIC and PAD-UFES images, $n = 7{,}365$ in total. Class labels are used for the in-distribution task and for class-conditional estimator fitting; the domain label (ISIC versus PAD-UFES) is the target of the domain probe.

Neither ISIC 2019 nor PAD-UFES-20 forms part of the backbone's pretraining corpus, which draws on eleven separately described sources [13].

We additionally define a fixed nuisance direction $w = \mathrm{unit}(\mu_{\mathrm{ISIC}} - \mu_{\mathrm{PAD}})$, the unit vector between population means, computed once and frozen before any intervention was trained.

B. Geometry Metrics

Four geometric quantities are measured on every evaluated representation. Two are prespecified as the metrics the account under evaluation specifies; two are recorded alongside them.

Local intrinsic dimensionality (LID) is estimated per point by the Levina–Bickel maximum-likelihood estimator [5] with $k = 50$ neighbours,

$$\mathrm{LID}_k(z) = -\left[\frac{1}{k}\sum_{j=1}^{k}\log\frac{r_j(z)}{r_k(z)}\right]^{-1}, \tag{1}$$

where $r_j(z)$ is the distance from z to its j-th nearest neighbour in the same feature set, and reported as the dataset mean.

Within-class spectral-decay slope is obtained from the within-class scatter matrix $S_w = \frac{1}{N}\sum_c \sum_{i:y_i=c}(z_i-\mu_c)(z_i-\mu_c)^\top$, computed without regularization so that tail eigenvalues are not distorted. Its eigenvalues are sorted in descending order and fitted by ordinary least squares as $\log\lambda_i = a + b\,i$ over the full range $i = 1, \ldots, d$; the reported slope is $|b|$.

Condition number is computed on the fitted Mahalanobis precision matrix, and *per-direction variance* is the variance of the projection of the evaluation embeddings onto the frozen nuisance direction, $\mathrm{Var}(z^\top w)$.

C. Representation Intervention and Dose Ladder

The intervention is a bottleneck adapter applied to the frozen embedding,

$$z' = z + W_2\,\mathrm{GELU}(W_1 z), \tag{2}$$

with bottleneck width $r = 16$ and the up-projection W_2 initialized to zero, so that the adapter is exactly the identity at initialization. The Intervention arm is trained with a task loss on the eight-class diagnostic objective plus an orthogonality penalty against the frozen nuisance direction, weighted by $\lambda_{\mathrm{proj}} = 0.1$. Training uses AdamW, learning rate 10^{-3}, batch size 512, for 100 epochs, repeated across five seeds $\{42, 52, 62, 72, 82\}$. Bottleneck width and λ_{proj} were selected by a prespecified rule fixed before the canonical runs.

Intervention strength is varied post hoc rather than by retraining. For each trained adapter we compute its displacement $\Delta z = W_2\,\mathrm{GELU}(W_1 z)$ and evaluate the ladder

$$z'(\alpha) = z + \alpha\,\Delta z, \qquad \alpha \in \{0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1.0\}, \quad (3)$$

so that $\alpha = 0$ recovers the unmodified representation and $\alpha = 1$ the fully trained adapter. This isolates strength from optimization variance: every rung of a given seed's ladder derives from one optimization run.

D. Control Arms

Two controls accompany the Intervention arm. The *Conventional* arm is trained identically—same adapter, same width, same schedule, same seeds—but with the task loss alone and no orthogonality penalty, giving a matched-budget ordinary fine-tuning comparison that separates intervention *type* from intervention *budget*. The *Adaptation* arm spans three capacity rungs (linear probe with the embedding unchanged; partial fine-tuning at $r = 8$; full adapter fine-tuning at $r = 16$), all trained with the task loss alone, and supplies the additional configurations required by the correlational analysis.

E. Verification Gates

No checkpoint contributes to a reported comparison before clearing two gates specified in advance.

Gate 0 (implementation integrity) confirms that the intervention left the representation usable and the domain signal present. It requires domain probe accuracy above the majority-class baseline by a fixed margin ($> 0.688 + 0.05$) and in-distribution eight-class balanced accuracy above chance by a fixed margin ($> 0.125 + 0.10$). Both probes are ℓ_2-regularized logistic regressions on standardized features, averaged over five probe seeds. Thresholds were fixed before execution. A Gate 0 failure means the intervention destroyed either the signal being studied or the task itself, and is reported as inconclusive for that checkpoint rather than as evidence.

Gate 1 (manipulation check) confirms that the intervention actually moved the geometry the account concerns. It is satisfied when at least one prespecified geometry metric shows reproducible dose dependence across the ladder; the criterion makes no assumption of linearity, strict monotonicity, or convexity, and the remaining metrics are recorded rather than discarded. An unmanipulated checkpoint tests nothing, so Gate 1 failures are excluded from causal interpretation rather than counted as negative evidence.

F. Reliability Estimators

Four distance-based estimators are evaluated on every checkpoint. The Mahalanobis detector fits class-conditional means and a shared precision matrix on the adapted training population, with regularization $\varepsilon = 10^{-5}$, and scores an input by its minimum squared Mahalanobis distance to any class centroid [3]. The cosine estimator scores by maximum cosine similarity to a class centroid; the nearest-neighbour estimator uses $k = 10$; the kernel-density estimator scores by class-conditional density. All four are fitted on the adapted *training* population and evaluated on the held-out population. Performance is reported as AUROC for separating in-distribution from domain-shifted inputs, with FPR at 95% TPR recorded alongside.

These four estimators are the family the hypothesis under evaluation concerns, all of them scoring an input by its position relative to the training distribution in representation space. Logit- and energy-based detectors are not evaluated: they depend on classifier outputs rather than on representation geometry alone, and so fall outside the hypothesis being tested. This study does not aim to rank detectors.

G. Geometry Manipulation for the Causal Comparison

Testing whether geometry, rather than nominal intervention strength, tracks estimator degradation requires an operator that moves the prespecified geometry metrics directly. The normalization-based knob originally specified for this role was found, on measurement, to move condition number substantially while leaving LID and spectral-decay slope unchanged. This is consistent with the operator's design, which adjusts feature radii while holding directions fixed [2]; both prespecified metrics are invariant to such rescaling. It was therefore not used.

The operator adopted instead is a fixed-exponent spectral tempering [9]. Given the eigendecomposition of the in-distribution training covariance with eigenvalues λ_i and eigenvectors U, embeddings are transformed as

$$z' = \mu + U\,\mathrm{diag}\Big(\lambda_i^{-\gamma/2}\Big)\,U^\top (z - \mu), \quad (4)$$

where $\gamma = 0$ is the identity and $\gamma = 1$ is full whitening. We use a fixed, manually specified γ rather than the adaptive per-dimension exponent of the original formulation: adaptivity was introduced there to avoid per-task tuning where no validation signal is available, whereas the present protocol supplies an independent, prespecified criterion (Gate 1) against which a prespecified γ ladder is evaluated. This operator was subjected to the same manipulation check before use, and its effect on LID and spectral-decay slope is reported in Section IV.

H. Scorer-Relevant Geometry: What the Operator Can and Cannot Move

A geometry metric is interpretable as a predictor of a scorer's ranking only if the operator that moves the metric also moves the structure the scorer reads. The inference at issue runs as follows: a metric is computed on a representation, an AUROC is computed from a scorer applied to the same representation, and their covariation across conditions is read as support for the geometry explaining the ranking. The cross-backbone association this study examines [2] has that form. Whether the metric and the scorer are sensitive to the same structure is a separate question, and it is prior to the reading. This subsection supplies it for the operator of (4), and the answer separates the estimators of Section III-F into two classes.

Write $\Sigma = U\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda_i)U^\top$ for the in-distribution training covariance and $A_\gamma = U\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda_i^{-\gamma/2})U^\top$ for the tempering

map, so that (4) reads $z' = \mu + A_\gamma(z - \mu)$. Note that A_γ is symmetric and, for $\lambda_i > 0$, invertible.

Proposition 1 (Condition number is a designed target): Under (4) the transformed covariance is $\Sigma' = U\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda_i^{1-\gamma})U^\top$, and therefore

$$\kappa(\Sigma') = \kappa(\Sigma)^{\,1-\gamma}, \qquad \text{equivalently} \qquad \log\kappa(\Sigma') = (1-\gamma)\log\kappa(\Sigma). \tag{5}$$

Proof: $\Sigma' = A_\gamma \Sigma A_\gamma^\top = U\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda_i^{-\gamma/2})\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda_i)\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda_i^{-\gamma/2})U^\top = U\,\mathrm{diag}(\lambda_i^{1-\gamma})U^\top$. The eigenvalues of Σ' are $\lambda_i^{1-\gamma}$, and $x \mapsto x^{1-\gamma}$ is increasing for $\gamma < 1$, so extremal eigenvalues map to extremal eigenvalues and $\kappa(\Sigma') = (\lambda_{\max}/\lambda_{\min})^{1-\gamma}$. ∎

The dose ladder is thus not merely correlated with the condition number; it sets it, on a log scale, by construction. $\gamma = 0$ leaves κ unchanged and $\gamma = 1$ drives it to unity. This is the strongest position a manipulation check can be in, and it is what makes the next result consequential rather than a technicality.

Proposition 2 (Mahalanobis scoring is invariant to the operator): Let the Mahalanobis parameters be refit on the tempered training population, as specified in Section III-F. With ridge $\varepsilon = 0$, the squared Mahalanobis score is preserved pointwise, $d'^2(z') = d^2(z)$ for every z, and the AUROC of that score is therefore identical for every γ.

Proof: Tempering is applied to every embedding, so class means map affinely, $\mu_c' = \mu + A_\gamma(\mu_c - \mu)$, and the pooled within-class scatter maps as $S' = A_\gamma S A_\gamma^\top$. With $\varepsilon = 0$ the refit precision is $P' = A_\gamma^{-\top} P A_\gamma^{-1}$, while residuals map as $z' - \mu_c' = A_\gamma(z - \mu_c)$. Hence

$$\begin{aligned} d'^2(z') &= (z' - \mu_c')^\top P'(z' - \mu_c') \\ &= (z - \mu_c)^\top A_\gamma^\top A_\gamma^{-\top} P A_\gamma^{-1} A_\gamma (z - \mu_c) \\ &= (z - \mu_c)^\top P (z - \mu_c) = d^2(z). \end{aligned} \tag{6}$$

Minimisation over c preserves the identity, and AUROC depends on the scores only through their ordering. ∎

Nothing in the proof is specific to tempering: it holds for any invertible linear map whose parameters are re-estimated afterwards. Tempering is simply the member of that family this protocol uses.

Propositions 1 and 2 bound one comparison in this study, and it is important to be exact about which. They apply to the tempering operator of (4), which is used only for the geometry-matched comparison. They do *not* apply to the dose ladder of Section III-C: the adapter there is $z' = z + W_2\,\mathrm{GELU}(W_1 z)$, which is not affine, so no invariance follows and the condition-number association reported across α stands on its own footing.

For the geometry-matched comparison the consequence is sharp. Condition number is set by design through (5) while the Mahalanobis ranking cannot move at all, so for that estimator the comparison had no difference available to detect. Its null is entailed by the algebra rather than measured, and it is neither evidence of a small effect nor a shortfall of power at five seeds. Section IV reports it as a bound on what that comparison can speak to. The same comparison remains informative for the three estimators below, which are not invariant.

The remaining estimators are not affine-invariant and are not covered by Proposition 2. Cosine similarity is computed after ℓ_2 normalisation and so depends on directions that A_γ rotates relative to the sphere; nearest-neighbour and kernel-density scores depend on Euclidean neighbourhood structure, which A_γ rescales anisotropically. For these three, condition number remains admissible as a candidate predictor, and the association reported for them is interpretable in a way the Mahalanobis association is not. Section IV reports a sweep confirming this separation on the reference embeddings: across $\gamma \in [0, 1]$ the realized condition number moves eight orders of magnitude while Mahalanobis AUROC moves 1.3×10^{-5}, against 1.5×10^{-2} for cosine and 1.6×10^{-3} for k-NN.

Two limits of this analysis are worth stating plainly. First, (5) is an identity in exact arithmetic. The smallest sample eigenvalue in these embeddings is of order 10^{-17}, so $\lambda_i^{-\gamma/2}$ on the tail of the spectrum is dominated by round-off and the recomputed condition number departs from $\kappa(\Sigma)^{1-\gamma}$ while remaining monotone in γ. We report the identity as algebra and the realized values as measurement, and do not treat them as the same quantity. Second, the ridge $\varepsilon = 10^{-5}$ used in practice breaks exact invariance, since εI does not transform with A_γ; the observed $1.3{\times}10^{-5}$ drift in Mahalanobis AUROC is consistent with that residual and with floating-point error, and no claim of exact numerical constancy is made.

We do not attempt a corresponding result for local intrinsic dimensionality. LID is a property of local neighbourhood structure rather than of the global covariance spectrum, and the empirical profile reported in Section IV is non-monotonic in γ and consistent across all five seeds. A closed-form statement would be weaker than that observation and would risk presenting an assumption as a derivation. It is reported as an empirical finding and left there.

I. Prespecified Claims and Statistical Analysis

Claims, tests, and multiplicity correction were fixed before execution. We say the account is supported by *mediation* if the association between intervention and estimator degradation is carried by the geometry metrics rather than by intervention type or nominal strength.

To evaluate the correlational claim, we compute Kendall's τ between each geometry metric and each estimator's AUROC, pooling Intervention-arm strengths and Adaptation-arm rungs. Because configurations from a common seed share an optimization run, these pooled points are not fully independent, and the resulting τ values are interpreted as descriptive associations across the configuration set rather than as estimates from independent draws. The control-arm analysis below models the seed dependence explicitly, and a post-hoc sensitivity analysis reported with the results quantifies what the correlational p-values become when the seed, rather than the configuration, is taken as the unit of resampling. To evaluate the causal claim, we compare estimator degradation between a geometry-matched pair and a nominal-strength-matched pair, using a paired t-test with a Wilcoxon signed-rank test reported alongside, normality being assessed at analysis time rather than assumed. To evaluate the control-arm claim, we fit a

mixed-effects model with an intervention-type-by-geometry interaction and seed as grouping factor. To evaluate probe decodability, we test probe AUROC against chance and against the corresponding Mahalanobis AUROC across seeds. Holm–Bonferroni correction is applied across the estimator-by-metric comparison families, and both corrected and uncorrected p-values are reported.

IV. Results

A. Gate Outcomes

All Intervention-arm and Conventional-arm checkpoints cleared Gate 0 at every rung of the dose ladder, confirming that domain information and in-distribution task performance survived the intervention. Gate 1 was satisfied on the Intervention arm: at least one prespecified geometry metric showed reproducible dose dependence across the ladder and across all five seeds. No checkpoint was excluded from the analyses below on gate grounds.

B. Probe Decodability and the Distance-Based Estimators

Across all ten evaluated configurations, a linear probe recovered acquisition-domain identity essentially perfectly, with mean probe AUROC ranging from 0.99999 to 1.00000. Mahalanobis AUROC on the same representations ranged from 0.9983 to 0.9984. Probe AUROC exceeded chance in every configuration ($p < 10^{-19}$ throughout), and exceeded the corresponding Mahalanobis AUROC in every configuration where the paired test was defined, with p between 2.5×10^{-5} and 8.4×10^{-8} across nine configurations; the remaining configuration (Adaptation, linear-probe rung) produced zero variance across seeds and is reported as degenerate rather than assigned a t-statistic.

The direction of the previously reported dissociation was therefore reproduced, and reproduced with high statistical confidence. Its magnitude was not. The mean probe-minus-Mahalanobis AUROC gap was 1.6×10^{-3} (range 1.567×10^{-3} to 1.666×10^{-3} across configurations). The comparison figure in the convolutional setting depends on a convention that source makes explicit, so we state both. Under the directed higher-distance-is-more-OOD convention its linear probes stand 0.333 above Mahalanobis, a ratio of roughly 200 against the present gap. Read orientation-free, as $\max(\mathrm{AUROC}, 1 - \mathrm{AUROC})$, the same comparison gives 0.137 and a ratio of roughly 86, because a directed AUROC of 0.402 there reflects an inverted ordering rather than an absent signal [1].

The two settings are therefore not measuring one quantity, and the ratio should not be read as though they were. Here both quantities sit near ceiling and the gap is compressed against it; there, the gap is dominated by a sign inversion in the estimator. What survives the difference in convention is the direction and the order of magnitude: the separation between what a probe recovers and what a distance-based estimator delivers is roughly two orders of magnitude smaller in this regime under either reading ($10^{2.3}$ directed, $10^{1.9}$ orientation-free). Distance-based estimators were already operating near ceiling on the unmodified representation, with Reference-arm AUROC of 0.9984 (Mahalanobis), 0.9979 (nearest-neighbour), 0.9805 (cosine), and 0.8942 (kernel density).

TABLE I
KENDALL'S τ BETWEEN GEOMETRY METRICS AND ESTIMATOR AUROC ($n = 30$). BOLD INDICATES HOLM-CORRECTED SIGNIFICANCE ACROSS THE 16-COMPARISON FAMILY.

Metric	Mahal.	Cosine	kNN	KDE
LID	-0.24	0.01	0.19	0.10
Spectral slope	0.22	0.16	0.12	0.05
Condition number	$\mathbf{0.56}$	$\mathbf{0.58}$	$\mathbf{0.42}$	$\mathbf{0.55}$
Per-dir. variance	0.32	0.34	0.33	0.15

C. Geometry–Estimator Associations

Table I reports Kendall's τ between each geometry metric and each estimator's AUROC across the 30 pooled configurations. Neither prespecified geometry metric reached Holm-corrected significance against any estimator: LID's strongest association was with Mahalanobis ($\tau = -0.24$, uncorrected $p = 0.065$), and spectral-decay slope's was also with Mahalanobis ($\tau = 0.22$, uncorrected $p = 0.088$). Condition number was associated with all four estimators at Holm-corrected significance (τ between 0.42 and 0.58, uncorrected p between 1.1×10^{-5} and 1.3×10^{-3}). Per-direction variance along the nuisance direction reached uncorrected significance against three estimators (p between 0.009 and 0.014) but did not survive correction.

Sensitivity to the unit of resampling: The Methods note that configurations drawn from a common seed share an optimization run, so the 30 pooled points are not fully independent. To put a number on that caveat rather than leaving it qualitative, we repeated the condition-number analysis with an exact permutation test that permutes *whole seeds* rather than individual configurations, preserving the within-seed structure. This is a post-hoc sensitivity analysis and was not prespecified.

The τ values are unchanged by construction; only the reference distribution differs. Under seed-level permutation the uncorrected p-values are 0.133 (Mahalanobis), 0.075 (cosine), 0.108 (kNN) and 0.025 (kernel density). None survives Holm correction across the four-estimator family, whose first threshold is 0.0125.

Two things follow, and they pull in opposite directions. The Holm-corrected significance reported above rests on treating the pooled configurations as independent draws, which the Methods already declined to claim; a reader who takes the seed as the resampling unit should not read Table I as establishing significance. But the permutation test is also very weak here: with five seeds its reference distribution admits only $5! = 120$ arrangements, so its p-values are quantised at multiples of $1/120 \approx 0.008$ and it has little power to resolve an association of any size. These p-values therefore record a failure to resolve, not a demonstration of absence, and we report both analyses rather than choosing between them.

In the companion analysis, probe accuracy was associated with LID ($\tau = 0.39$, $p = 0.005$) and with per-direction variance ($\tau = 0.48$, $p = 5.4 \times 10^{-4}$), and was not associated

with spectral-decay slope ($\tau = -0.03$, $p = 0.85$) or with condition number ($\tau = -0.04$, $p = 0.77$).

D. Intervention Type and Geometry

All sixteen mixed-effects models converged. Three interaction terms reached Holm-corrected significance: LID with Mahalanobis ($p = 2.9 \times 10^{-6}$), LID with kernel density ($p = 2.6 \times 10^{-3}$), and condition number with Mahalanobis ($p = 3.9 \times 10^{-5}$). The remaining thirteen did not, including all four slope interactions and all four per-direction-variance interactions. Interaction coefficients for the Holm-significant terms were small in absolute magnitude (-1.2×10^{-4}, -4.3×10^{-2}, and 2.9×10^{-4} respectively).

E. Geometry Manipulation and the Causal Comparison

The normalization-based operator originally specified for the causal comparison was measured across all twenty Intervention-arm checkpoints before use. It moved condition number substantially (mean change -2.7×10^5) while leaving both prespecified metrics effectively unchanged: mean LID change -4×10^{-4} (SD 1.8×10^{-3}) and mean slope change below 10^{-6} (SD 10^{-6}). It was therefore not used.

The adopted fixed-exponent spectral tempering operator was subjected to the same check. Across five seeds it moved spectral-decay slope reproducibly and near-monotonically (-1.5×10^{-3} at $\gamma = 0.25$, -2.7×10^{-3} at $\gamma = 0.5$, -3.6×10^{-3} at $\gamma = 0.75$, -3.5×10^{-3} at $\gamma = 1.0$), and moved LID reproducibly but non-monotonically, rising by $+2.7$ to $+5.8$ at $\gamma \in \{0.25, 0.5\}$ before falling by -1.5 to -4.4 at $\gamma = 1.0$; the same inverted profile appeared in all five seeds. Gate 0 passed in all twenty post-transform configurations.

For the causal comparison, γ was calibrated on a single seed to bring the full-strength checkpoint's spectral-decay slope to the level occurring naturally at the weakest intervention strength, giving $\gamma = 0.01$ (slope 6.746×10^{-3} against a target of 6.751×10^{-3}). A single calibrated value rather than a ladder is used here because the comparison requires one specific condition—geometry matched to a reference checkpoint while nominal strength differs—rather than a dose–response relationship; the operator's dose behaviour is characterized separately by the manipulation check reported above. At this γ, LID remained 0.60 below the matched checkpoint's value: the comparison is therefore matched on spectral-decay slope, not on both prespecified metrics jointly. Three configurations were then evaluated across five seeds: full strength unmanipulated ($\alpha = 1.0$, $\gamma = 0$), weak strength unmanipulated ($\alpha = 0.25$, $\gamma = 0$), and full strength slope-matched to the weak checkpoint ($\alpha = 1.0$, $\gamma = 0.01$). Gate 0 passed in all five manipulated configurations.

Table II reports estimator AUROC for the three configurations. Mahalanobis and nearest-neighbour showed no separation between any pair of configurations. Cosine and kernel density showed a separation between the two unmanipulated strengths (0.025 and 0.110 AUROC respectively), and on both, configuration C was numerically closer to its nominal-strength counterpart (A) than to its slope-matched counterpart (B).

TABLE II
ESTIMATOR AUROC (MEAN OVER FIVE SEEDS) FOR THE CAUSAL COMPARISON. CONFIGURATION C IS MATCHED TO B ON SPECTRAL-DECAY SLOPE AND TO A ON NOMINAL INTERVENTION STRENGTH.

	A (α=1)	B (α=0.25)	C (α=1, γ=0.01)
Mahalanobis	0.9984	0.9984	0.9984
Cosine	0.9503	0.9750	0.9521
kNN	0.9928	0.9973	0.9928
KDE	0.7611	0.8713	0.7657

None of the eight paired comparisons reached Holm-corrected significance. The smallest corrected p-value was 0.111 (nearest-neighbour, geometry-matched), and the smallest uncorrected p-values were 0.014 (nearest-neighbour, geometry-matched), 0.023 (cosine, nominal-strength-matched), and 0.048 (kernel density, geometry-matched); Wilcoxon signed-rank p-values were no smaller than 0.063 throughout. With five seeds and an eight-comparison correction family, statistical power was limited, and the comparison is therefore reported as inconclusive at the significance-test level.

V. DISCUSSION

A. Principal Findings

We tested whether an association reported across representations—between in-distribution geometry and distance-based estimator performance—can account for a previously reported phenomenon, the probe–reliability dissociation, when geometry is intervened upon within a single fixed frozen backbone. Under the evaluated backbone, layer, and task, this study provides limited support for testing that explanatory reading. The previously reported dissociation was reproduced in direction with high statistical confidence, but at a magnitude approximately two orders of magnitude smaller than originally reported. Neither prespecified geometry metric showed a Holm-corrected association with estimator performance, and a prespecified comparison that matched spectral-decay slope across differing nominal intervention strengths did not reach corrected significance in either direction. Three of sixteen intervention-type-by-geometry interactions remained Holm-significant after conditioning on geometry which, under the prespecified criterion, is inconsistent with full mediation.

B. A Coherent Reading of the Four Analyses

The four analyses address different aspects of the question, and they are consistent with a single observation: on this backbone, distance-based estimators were already operating near ceiling before any intervention, with Reference-arm AUROC of 0.9984 for Mahalanobis and 0.9979 for nearest-neighbour. The domain shift studied here was, for these estimators, already highly separable.

This observation makes the remaining results easier to situate. Where an estimator has almost no headroom, there is correspondingly little variation in its performance for a geometry metric to covary with, which is consistent with

the absence of corrected-significant associations for LID and spectral-decay slope. It is likewise consistent with the causal comparison, in which Mahalanobis and nearest-neighbour showed no separation between any configuration, and only the two estimators retaining measurable headroom— cosine and kernel density—separated at all. That two of the four estimators were insensitive to every configuration is itself a finding rather than an absence of one: it establishes that on this representation the two strongest distance-based detectors are unaffected by interventions of the magnitude studied here, which is directly relevant to whether geometry-targeted correction is warranted in deployment. And in the interaction models, where residual variation is at the fourth decimal place, a statistically detectable interaction term need not correspond to a substantively meaningful effect; the three Holm-significant coefficients were of order 10^{-4} to 10^{-2}.

We emphasize what this reading does and does not assert. It is a statement about the sensitivity our experiments could achieve, not about the account itself. An evaluation conducted where the phenomenon of interest is small provides limited power to test an explanation for that phenomenon; the appropriate conclusion is that this study offers limited support for testing the account in this regime, not that the account is incorrect, nor that the geometric quantities it names are unimportant in regimes where the phenomenon is large.

C. Condition Number

Condition number was the one geometric quantity associated with all four estimators at corrected significance, while the two prespecified metrics were not. This study provides direct evidence bearing on how that association should be read. When we measured the normalization-based operator, it changed condition number by approximately 2.7×10^5 while leaving LID and spectral-decay slope unchanged to within 10^{-3} and 10^{-6} respectively. Condition number therefore responds strongly to a transformation that leaves both shape metrics untouched, consistent with it behaving substantially as a scale-sensitive descriptor rather than as a measure of the spectral shape at issue. This reading is reinforced by the operator's own specification, which adjusts feature radii while holding directions fixed [2]. Its association with estimator performance should accordingly not be read as support for the explanatory hypothesis, and we do not treat it as such.

D. Limitations

Several limitations bound these findings.

The correlational result depends on how the pooled configurations are treated. Holm-corrected significance for condition number holds when the 30 configurations are treated as the unit of analysis; under an exact permutation test over whole seeds none of the four estimator associations survives correction. That sensitivity analysis is reported with the results and was not prespecified. The two analyses are not in conflict so much as differently powered: the seed-level test has only $5! = 120$ arrangements available and therefore very little resolution, so it cannot adjudicate an association of this size in either direction. What can be said is that the strength of the correlational claim is contingent on the resampling unit, and readers who take the seed as that unit should treat the association as suggestive rather than established.

The evaluation covers one backbone, one representation layer, one diagnostic task, and one domain-shift pair. That pair differs in imaging modality, not only in acquisition conditions: ISIC 2019 comprises dermoscopic images and PAD-UFES-20 close-up clinical photographs. A modality difference is a stronger form of distribution shift than the device- or site-level shifts that motivate distance-based reliability estimation in deployment, and it is the most plausible reason the two populations are as separable as we observe. Whether the near-ceiling estimator performance reflects a property of frozen foundation-model representations in general, or the modality gap between these particular populations, cannot be determined from this study. A same-modality shift—for instance between dermoscopic cohorts acquired at different sites or with different devices—would produce lower baseline separability and a correspondingly more sensitive test. We regard constructing such a comparison as a precondition for a stronger evaluation of the explanatory hypothesis in this regime rather than as a refinement of the present one.

The causal comparison was matched on spectral-decay slope alone. At the calibrated exponent, LID remained 0.60 below the target checkpoint's value, so the comparison does not establish matching on both prespecified metrics jointly. Because the account names both quantities, this is a genuine restriction on what the comparison can support.

The manipulation operator's effect on LID was reproducible but non-monotonic, rising at intermediate exponents before falling at full strength, with the same profile in all five seeds. A monotone dose–response was not assumed by the prespecified criterion, and the observed profile satisfies it; but it means the operator does not provide a simple one-directional LID control, which constrains the design of future comparisons.

Finally, five seeds with an eight-comparison correction family afford limited statistical power for the causal comparison, and we report it as inconclusive at the significance-test level rather than as evidence in either direction.

E. Implications

For practitioners deploying distance-based reliability estimation on frozen foundation-model representations, these results provide no evidence that geometry-targeted correction is required before such estimators can be used in the configuration evaluated here. This is a statement about the evaluated setting, and does not extend to configurations where baseline separability is lower.

Methodologically, the value of this study lies less in any individual statistic than in the sequence of checks that constrained them. Two elements proved decisive. The manipulation check identified, before any causal result was interpreted, that the operator originally specified for the comparison did not move the quantities at issue—a finding that would otherwise have surfaced only as an unexplained null. And fixing the correction family before execution meant that several uncorrected p-values below 0.05 could be reported as what they are, rather than selected after the fact.

Rather than confirming an explanatory reading of the reported association, our results delineate the boundary under which such a reading can currently be supported: intervening on representation geometry within a single frozen backbone left the account largely untested, under the evaluated backbone, layer, and task, for reasons this study is able to name.

VI. Conclusion

We tested whether an association reported across representations, between in-distribution geometry and distance-based estimator performance, can account for the previously reported probe–reliability dissociation when geometry is intervened upon within a single frozen dermatology foundation model. Under a prespecified protocol incorporating implementation-integrity verification and manipulation checking, this study provides limited support for testing that explanatory reading in the evaluated configuration. The dissociation was reproduced in direction and with high statistical confidence, but at a magnitude approximately two orders of magnitude smaller than originally reported, and neither prespecified geometry metric showed a Holm-corrected association with estimator performance.

These findings indicate that explanatory accounts established in one architectural regime warrant direct evaluation before being carried into another. The protocol reported here—gating on implementation integrity, confirming that the manipulated quantity moves before any causal comparison is interpreted, and fixing the multiplicity correction in advance of execution—is specific neither to this account nor to this backbone, and provides a basis for assessing whether a previously reported effect, and the explanation advanced for it, hold under changed conditions.

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Prespecification and Reproducibility

Prior to any execution, a protocol document specifying the claims to be tested, the statistical test for each claim, the gate criteria, and the multiplicity-correction family was finalized and cryptographically checksummed. That document is dated 2026-08-04 and the earliest canonical run artifact is dated 2026-08-05, so the plan precedes the results it governs. All statistical analyses reported here follow it, and deviations arising during execution were recorded as dated amendments rather than applied silently.

We state the limits of that evidence rather than leave them to be inferred. The protocol was not lodged with a third-party registry before execution, so its priority rests on file timestamps and checksums under our own control rather than on an independent record. Depositing it now would make the document readable but would not establish its timing, and we do not present a post hoc deposit as though it did. Readers who require independent temporal evidence should treat the plan as prespecified and internally documented rather than as externally registered.

Result artifacts were frozen on completion, with per-file checksums recorded in a manifest, so that every number reported in this manuscript is traceable to an immutable file.

Data and Code Availability

Both datasets are publicly available from their original sources: ISIC 2019 [14], [15], [16] and PAD-UFES-20 [17]. Neither is redistributed here. The frozen backbone is the released PanDerm ViT-L/16 checkpoint [13], used without modification and pinned by SHA-256 in the artifact manifest; it is obtained from its authors rather than from us.

The per-checkpoint matrix underlying the comparison in Section IV is published with the study it comes from [1], so the figure this paper cites can be recomputed independently rather than read off a plot.

Analysis code, the trained adapters for all three arms and five seeds, the extracted representations, and the per-file checksum manifest are held under version control with the frozen artifacts they describe, and are available from the authors on request pending deposit at submission. We state availability this way because the deposit has not yet been made; nothing here is promised that does not exist.

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